

ORANGE COUNTY NURSING SCHOOL PATHWAY GUIDE

ADN, BSN, ABSN, and
Nursing Application Strategy

NURSING SCHOOL



RN FUTURE
Your Next Chapter



PREREQUISITES
Build a Strong
Foundation



TEAS
Prepare with
Confidence



**HEALTHCARE
EXPERIENCE**
Gain Meaningful
Experience



**APPLICATION
STRATEGY**
Stand Out and
Get Selected



SCHOOL OPTIONS
Research programs.
Understand requirements.



FIRST STEP
— HEALTHCARE ACADEMY —

Start Here. Grow in Healthcare.

Prepared by:
First Step Healthcare Academy



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★ 1. Quick Comparison of RN Pathways

 Pathway	 Best For	 Approx. Cost	 Main Advantage	 Main Disadvantage	 Entry Difficulty	 Time to RN
1  Public ADN	Budget-conscious students, working adults, local applicants	~\$4,000–\$8,000+	Lowest-cost RN pathway	Highly competitive; may require repeated applications	 High	 ~2 years after prerequisites
2  Public BSN	Students wanting a university BSN from the start	~\$30,000–\$45,000	BSN degree from the start	Very competitive; longer route	 Very High	 ~4 years total
3  Public ABSN	Students with a prior bachelor's degree	~\$35,000–\$50,000	Faster than traditional BSN; lower cost than many private options	Limited seats; intense full-time pace	 Very High	 ~15 months–2 years after prerequisites
4  Private BSN	Students wanting direct entry and predictable start dates	~\$125,000–\$160,000+	Multiple starts; more predictable timeline	High tuition and debt risk	 Moderate–High	 ~3–4 years depending on transfer credits
5  Private ABSN	Second-degree students wanting a fast BCN → RN pathway	~\$60,000–\$190,000+	Fastest BSN option for many second-degree students	Expensive and academically intense	 Moderate–High	 ~15–24 months after prerequisites



COST NOTE:

Estimates may not include housing, transportation, textbooks, health requirements, background checks, interest, lost wages, or personal expenses.



PLANNING TIP:

Many future nursing students begin with a lower-cost healthcare certification, such as CNA, while completing prerequisites and exploring nursing school options.

2.

WHAT MAKES A COMPETITIVE NURSING SCHOOL APPLICANT?

Most nursing programs evaluate applicants using multiple factors, not just one GPA or test score.

Golden West College's ADN Program uses a **Multi-Criteria Guidelines point system** that may consider academic performance, TEAS scores, healthcare experience, volunteer experience, and other criteria.

Some healthcare experiences may receive more consideration than others.

Under Golden West College's guidelines, applicants with at least **500** hours of qualifying direct patient-care experience, such as CNA, LVN, or EMT, may receive up to **20 admission points**, compared with up to **10 points** for roles such as Medical Assistant or Medical Scribe, and up to **5 points** for qualifying volunteer experience.

ADMISSION POINTS FOR EXPERIENCE



Direct Patient-Care Experience
(CNA, LVN, EMT, etc.)
Up to **20 points**



Related Clinical Roles
(Medical Assistant, Medical Scribe, etc.)
Up to **10 points**



Qualifying Volunteer Experience
Up to **5 points**



KEY TAKEAWAY:

Strong nursing school applicants build multiple areas of their application rather than relying on one factor.



2.1 GPA & PREREQUISITE COURSEWORK

Nursing programs usually require prerequisite courses such as:



- Anatomy
- Physiology
- Microbiology
- English Composition
- Psychology
- Statistics
- Communication

Many programs use grades in these courses as a major part of the selection process. Local ADN programs such as Golden West College, Saddleback College, Cerritos College, and Santa Ana College **award points based on science prerequisite performance**, especially Anatomy, Physiology, and Microbiology.



NOT ALL COURSES ARE WEIGHTED EQUALLY.

Some courses mainly require completion, while key science prerequisites can strongly affect competitiveness.



Some programs also award extra points for additional coursework completion, such as:

- Pharmacology
- Medical Terminology
- Statistics
- Critical Thinking
- Psychology
- Communication/Public Speaking
- Growth & Development
- Fundamentals of Aging
- Nursing Preparation Courses



THE PRACTICAL LESSON:

Do more than complete the minimum requirements—**plan your schedule strategically**. Avoid stacking too many GPA-critical science courses in one semester if it may hurt your performance.

2.2 ★ TEAS EXAMINATION PERFORMANCE

The **Test of Essential Academic Skills (TEAS)** is a common nursing entrance exam. It evaluates academic readiness in four areas:

TEAS Section	Approx. Questions
 Reading	45
 Mathematics	38
 Science	50
 English & Language Usage	37

The TEAS has approximately **170 questions** and takes about **3.5 hours**. The TEAS is often not just pass/fail. Many programs award points based on score ranges, so a higher score may significantly improve competitiveness. For example, some programs may award high points for scores in the **90–100%** range and much fewer points for scores near the minimum passing range.



WHAT STUDENTS SHOULD KNOW

- TEAS is often not just pass/fail.
- Higher scores may earn more admission points.
- Schools may have different minimum scores, retake rules, accepted versions, and deadlines.
- TEAS can be one of the largest admission categories.



PRACTICAL LESSON: Treat the TEAS as a scoring opportunity, not just a requirement. Plan preparation early and learn each target school's TEAS policy.

2.3 ★ HEALTHCARE EXPERIENCE & CERTIFICATION

Many nursing programs consider healthcare experience during admissions. For impacted programs, healthcare experience and certification can make an applicant more competitive. Not all healthcare experience is valued equally. Direct patient-care roles such as **CNA, LVN, or EMT** may receive more points than healthcare support roles or volunteer experience.



HOW HEALTHCARE EXPERIENCE CAN HELP STUDENTS

- Explore whether healthcare is the right fit
- Build confidence around patients
- Understand healthcare team roles
- Reinforce classroom concepts such as vital signs, infection control, documentation, safety, communication, and medical terminology



WHAT STUDENTS SHOULD KNOW

- Many programs recognize healthcare experience.
- Direct patient-care roles may receive greater consideration.
- Certifications can help students qualify for paid healthcare experience.
- Healthcare exposure can support both application strength and academic readiness.



PRACTICAL LESSON: Start early. Unlike TEAS preparation, healthcare experience often takes months to accumulate. Many aspiring nurses choose CNA training as an entry point because it provides direct patient-care experience, healthcare exposure, and opportunities to work while completing prerequisites. First Step Healthcare Academy offers state-approved CNA training designed to help students begin building healthcare experience and confidence on their nursing journey.



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3. NURSING APPLICATION STRATEGY: HOW TO AVOID LOSING POINTS



The goal is not only to become eligible.
The goal is to avoid losing points that could have been planned for months earlier.



1

LESSON #1



RESEARCH SCHOOLS BEFORE PLANNING CLASSES

- Some classes are required just to apply; others may increase the application score.
- Students may miss points from missing support courses such as Pharmacology, Statistics, Communication, Critical Thinking, Medical Terminology, Psychology, or nursing-preparation courses.
- Many applicants prepare for only one school. If they are not accepted, they may lose months waiting for another cycle.



SMART MOVE:

Choose 3 target schools with similar criteria. For each school, mark each course as:

- 1 Required to apply
- 2 Counts toward GPA or science GPA
- 3 May provide extra points after completion

2

LESSON #2



BUILD HEALTHCARE EXPERIENCE DURING PREREQUISITES

- Healthcare experience is hard to build at the last minute because it often takes months to accumulate.
- Direct patient-care roles such as CNA, LVN, or EMT may be valued higher than volunteer or limited-contact roles.
- **Better approach:** Begin gaining healthcare exposure while completing prerequisites.
- CNA certification can help students work and expand networks in healthcare, gain practical exposure to patient care, and develop experience that makes their application significantly more competitive.



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LESSON #3



TREAT THE TEAS AS A COMPETITIVE OPPORTUNITY

- The TEAS is not just another checklist item.
- Many programs award points by score range, so a higher score may improve competitiveness.
- **Takeaway:** Prepare early. Even 30 minutes of focused review each day over several months may be more effective than cramming before the exam.
- Also review each school's minimum score, retake policy, accepted version, and deadline.



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LESSON #4



PREPARE FOR MULTIPLE APPLICATIONS AND DEADLINES

- Applications often require more than transcripts and test scores, including proof of healthcare experience, certifications, degrees, volunteer work, residency status, language proficiency, or other criteria.
- Avoid preparing for only one school or one application cycle.
- Do not lose points because a document was missing, incomplete, or requested too late.



SMART MOVE:

Create an application tracker with targeted schools' requirements, application windows, and supplemental documentation.



Every point you earn is a step ahead. Plan early. Stay organized. Submit complete.
Give yourself the best chance to get in.



4. LOCAL PUBLIC ADN PROGRAMS

School	Degree	Typical Application Timing	Selection / Point System	Published Competitiveness / Size	Published Cost
 Cerritos College — Norwalk	ADN / RN	Usually Jan.–Feb. annual cycle	MSC process; 50% highest points and 50% lottery	Applicant count not clearly published; BRN lists 100 annual enrollment	 ~\$6,300
 Cypress College — Cypress	ADN / RN	Commonly February for Fall and September for Spring	30-point ranking system; 75% rank list and 25% lottery	Applicant count not clearly published; BRN lists 84 annual enrollment	 ~\$9,493
 Golden West College — Huntington Beach	ADN / RN	Feb. 1–15 for Fall; July 1–15 for Spring	Multi-Criteria Guidelines; no waitlist; admission not guaranteed	Applicant count not clearly published; BRN lists 200 annual enrollment	 ~\$7,302
 Santa Ana College — Santa Ana	ADN / RN	Historically Feb. 1–15 for Fall and Sept. 1–15 for Spring	Multi-criteria points grid; 20% random, 75% highest points, 20 alternates	Reported 600+ applicants/semester ; about 60 Fall and 40 Spring RN students	 ~\$5,765–\$6,000
 Saddleback College — Mission Viejo	ADN / RN	Usually February for Fall and July for Spring	100-point multi-criteria system; recent Fall 2026 cutoff 82 initial / 75 final	About 60 admitted/cycle plus 25–30 alternates ; older packet reported 200–300 applications/cycle	 ~\$5,386





5. BSN PROGRAMS IN AND NEAR ORANGE COUNTY

Explore public BSN programs at universities in and near Orange County. Use this comparison to understand application timing, admissions considerations, program size, and estimated costs.

School	BSN Pathway	Typical Application Timing	Selection / Admissions Notes	Published Competitiveness / Size	Published Cost
 Cal State Fullerton — Fullerton — Public	Traditional BSN, UDT BSN, ABSN	 CSU applications generally Aug. 1–Nov. 30	 Impacted; holistic review; UDT may consider GPA bracketing, Casper, work, or volunteer experience	 BRN lists 80 annual enrollment	 ~\$33,116
 UC Irvine — Irvine — Public	BS in Nursing Science	 UC applications generally due Nov. 30	 UC holistic admission; transfer applicants need strong prerequisite grades	 Reported 5,885 freshman applicants for 65 seats ; BRN lists 50 annual enrollment	 ~\$76,398
 Cal State Long Beach — Long Beach — Public	Traditional BSN	 Spring: Aug. 1–31; Fall: Oct. 1–Nov. 30	 Considers prerequisites and Casper; selected applicants complete interview/writing/oral phase	 Top 75–80 applicants admitted; BRN lists 228 annual enrollment	 ~\$27,552
 Cal State LA — Los Angeles — Public	Traditional BSN, ABSN	 CSU Apply generally due Nov. 30; NursingCAS may be later	 Considers TEAS, GPA, healthcare/volunteer experience, and local preference	 About 70 slots for 700 applicants ; BRN lists 100 annual enrollment	 ~\$32,180



TIP FOR APPLICANTS

Application deadlines and requirements can change. Always confirm the most current information on official university and School of Nursing websites.



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5. BSN PROGRAMS

in and Near Orange County

 School	 Degree	 Typical Application Timing	 Selection / Admissions Notes	 Published Competitiveness / Size	 Published Cost
Stanbridge University — Irvine / OC — Private	BSN	Multiple starts yearly	Ranked rubric may include entrance exam, prerequisites, GPA, healthcare certification, work/volunteer experience, and interview/essay	BRN lists 460 annual enrollment	~\$142,995
CNI College — Santa Ana — Private	BSN	Cohort-based starts	May include application, interview/campus tour, education requirements, and TEAS/HESI testing	BRN lists 250 annual enrollment	~\$147,450
Vanguard University — Costa Mesa — Private	BSN	Traditional cycle; verify annually	University and nursing-program review	BRN lists 30 annual enrollment	~\$159,400
West Coast University OC — Anaheim — Private	BSN	Rolling/cohort-based starts	Seat-based admissions; requirements must be completed before seat/start assignment	BRN lists 2,880 annual enrollment across WCU campuses	~\$148,253



Note: Published costs may reflect tuition, program fees, or BRN-reported total program cost and can change over time. Verify current cost, payment plans, and aid availability directly with each school.



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6. ABSN Programs in and Near Orange County

School	ABSN Pathway	Typical Application Timing	Selection / Admissions Notes	Published Competitiveness / Size	Published Cost
 Cal State Fullerton — Fullerton — Public	ABSN for students with prior bachelor's degree	Fall only; Cal State Apply generally Aug. 1–Nov. 30	Requires CSUF and School of Nursing admission; considers GPA, prerequisites, Casper, interview, experience, essay, and other factors	 CSUF reports 600–800 applications and about 200 qualified applicants	 BRN lists ~\$33,116; verify ABSN tuition
 Concordia University Irvine — Irvine — Private	ABSN for prior degree or 65 eligible credits	Cohort-based; deadlines vary	15-month full-time ABSN; considers prerequisites, GPA, prior coursework, application materials, and fit	 BRN lists 408 annual enrollment	 ~\$60,000–\$62,000
 Cal State LA — Los Angeles — Public	ABSN for students with prior bachelor's degree	Summer admission; recent cycle Nov.–early Jan. through NursingCAS	15-month self-support ABSN	 BRN lists 100 annual enrollment	 ~\$39,615+
 Cal State Northridge — Northridge — Public	ABSN for students with prior bachelor's degree	Cohort-based; recent Fall 2027 deadline July 28, 2026 or sooner	15-month cohort; prior bachelor's required; no TEAS required	 BRN lists 120 annual enrollment	 ~\$46,400
 Mount Saint Mary's University — LA — Private	ABSN for students with prior bachelor's degree	Summer: Aug. 1–Nov. 1; Fall: Dec. 1–Mar. 1	Cohort-based ABSN; verify prerequisites and GPA directly	 About 40 students/cohort; BRN lists 178 annual enrollment	 ~\$186,960
 Azusa Pacific University — Azusa / Monrovia — Private	Entry-Level Master's, not BSN; accelerated RN pathway	Timing varies	Graduate-entry RN pathway for students with prior bachelor's degree	 BRN lists APU under entry-level master's programs	 ~\$138,029



Program details, costs, and deadlines change frequently.

Always verify the most current information directly with each school and the BRN.



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NEXT STEP: START BUILDING HEALTHCARE EXPERIENCE EARLY



Every step you take today
brings you closer to the
nurse **you** want to become.

Nursing school preparation is not only about finishing prerequisites. Strong applicants need to build multiple areas of their application over time, including GPA, healthcare experience, TEAS preparation, support courses, and documentation.

If nursing is your long-term goal, one practical early step is gaining healthcare exposure while completing prerequisite coursework.

CNA TRAINING CAN HELP STUDENTS:



Gain **direct patient-care experience**



Build **confidence** in healthcare settings



Explore whether nursing is the
right long-term fit



Work while completing prerequisites



Strengthen future applications where
healthcare experience is considered



First Step Healthcare Academy

offers state-approved CNA training designed to help students begin building healthcare experience, confidence, and a clearer path toward nursing school.



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TAKE YOUR NEXT STEP TODAY!

Start building the experience, confidence, and future you need to get into nursing school.



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firststephealthcare.com



CALL
(714) 552-7707



LOCATIONS
Orange County, CA